

AISH Policy Manual — Three-Version Comparison

What changed across April 15 → July 2 → July 21, 2026, and whether it helps or harms recipients

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Bottom line

These are three dated snapshots of the same Government of Alberta AISH Policy Manual. The change that matters is not spread evenly across them — it lands almost entirely between April and July. The April 15 manual (180 pages) is the old AISH-only manual. The July 2 manual (212 pages) is a top-to-bottom rewrite that folds in a brand-new second program, ADAP (Alberta Disability Assistance Program), effective July 1, 2026. The July 21 manual (214 pages) is essentially the same July 2 content, cleanly re-published with a couple of pages added.

Overall direction for recipients: mixed, but net worse for most existing AISH recipients who work or who get moved to ADAP. It is arguably better for people who were previously shut out of AISH entirely, because ADAP creates a benefit where none existed for them.

The three versions at a glance

Manual	Pages	Dated	What it is
AISH MANUAL.pdf	180	Apr 15, 2026	Pre-ADAP baseline. AISH only. ADAP appears just 4 times, in passing.
AISH Manual 07-02-2026.pdf	212	Jul 2, 2026	The overhaul. AISH + ADAP fully integrated; every page re-dated Jul 2, 2026. +32 pages of new/rewritten policy.
AISH Manual-07-21-2026.pdf	214	Jul 21, 2026	Clean official re-publish of the July 2 content (all pages still dated Jul 2). +2 pages. Differences from July 2 are minor.

Because July 2 and July 21 are substantively the same, most of this report compares **April (old)** against **July (new)**, then notes the small July-to-July differences separately.

Change summary — old vs new

Area	April 15 (old)	July (new)	Impact
Programs covered	AISH only	AISH + new ADAP tier for people with a severe disability assessed as able to work	Mixed
Max monthly living allowance	AISH: \$1,940	AISH: \$1,940 (unchanged) • ADAP: \$1,740	Worse
Employment income exemption	More generous: a fully-exempt threshold plus a partial-exemption band above it	AISH: \$350 fully exempt, nothing above (hard cliff) • ADAP: \$700 with progressive deduction	Worse
Application	AISH application	Single “Disability Income Assistance (DIA)” application feeds both AISH and ADAP	Mixed

Area	April 15 (old)	July (new)	Impact
Medical eligibility	AISH severe-disability test	Split test: AISH = “permanently unable to work”; ADAP = “significantly restricts but does not prevent” work. New Medical Review Panel.	Mixed
Existing recipients	N/A	New “eligibility review of existing cases” — existing AISH files reassessed; some move to the lower ADAP rate	Worse
Asset limits	\$100,000 non-exempt / \$5,000 personal benefits	\$100,000 / \$5,000 (unchanged)	Same
Canada Disability Benefit	Non-exempt (clawed back) for standard AISH	Non-exempt (clawed back) — unchanged	Same
Health & personal benefits	AISH health/personal benefits	Carried over; ADAP clients keep health/personal benefits regardless of employment income	Same

Verdict key: **Worse** / **Better** / **Mixed** / **Same** — judged from the recipient's perspective.

What's genuinely new in July

These sections exist in the July manuals but not in April:

- **ADAP, a second disability program:** A parallel tier for people with a severe disability who are assessed as able to work, paying \$1,740/month vs AISH's \$1,940.
- **Combined DIA application:** One “Disability Income Assistance” application and medical report now routes an applicant to AISH, ADAP, or neither.
- **Medical Review Panel:** A new body of health professionals that makes final medical-eligibility determinations and rules on contested cases.
- **Progressive deduction model:** A new way of reducing ADAP benefits as earnings rise, replacing the old flat exemption approach. A “benefit estimator” tool is referenced (absent in April).
- **Eligibility review of existing cases:** Explicit policy for reassessing people already on AISH — the mechanism by which existing recipients can be transitioned to ADAP.
- **ADAP-specific rules:** New pages on ADAP client responsibilities, ADAP clients accessing training, and moving from ADAP to Enduring/Alberta health benefits.

Where it is better

- **A benefit for the previously excluded.** People who could not meet AISH's “permanently unable to work” bar previously got nothing from this program. ADAP gives them income, health benefits, and employment support.
- **More room to earn on ADAP than on AISH.** ADAP's \$700 fully-exempt plus progressive deduction lets ADAP clients keep more earned income than AISH's \$350 hard cap, which is consistent with ADAP's design around working.

- **Health/personal benefits protected while working.** ADAP clients keep their health and personal benefits regardless of employment income.

Where it is worse

- **The AISH earnings cliff.** AISH's employment exemption becomes \$350 fully exempt with nothing above it — a hard cliff, and clearly less generous than April's threshold-plus-partial-exemption model. Working AISH clients keep less.
- **\$200/month less on ADAP.** ADAP's \$1,740 living allowance is \$200 below AISH's \$1,940. Anyone reassessed from AISH to ADAP loses \$200/month (before any temporary transition top-up).
- **Reassessment risk for existing recipients.** The new “eligibility review of existing cases” creates a path to move people off AISH onto the lower ADAP rate — a downside that simply did not exist in the April manual.
- **More gatekeeping.** A split medical test plus a Medical Review Panel adds an eligibility-sorting layer that determines who lands on the higher vs lower benefit.

What stayed the same

The AISH maximum living allowance (\$1,940), the asset limits (\$100,000 non-exempt / \$5,000 for personal benefits), the dollar-for-dollar Canada Disability Benefit clawback for standard AISH clients, and the general shape of health and personal benefits all carry over from April into July unchanged.

July 2 vs July 21 — the small stuff

The July 21 manual carries the same ADAP integration as July 2: identical \$350 / \$700 / \$1,100 / \$1,500 exemption table, the same \$1,740 ADAP and \$1,940 AISH living allowances, and the same Medical Review Panel. Every policy page in the July 21 file is still dated “Jul 02, 2026,” and the file grew by only two pages. The practical read: July 21 is a cleaner official re-publish of July 2 with minor additions/corrections, not a new round of policy change.

Method & caveats

The July 21 PDF had a genuine text layer, so its figures are quoted directly. The April 15 and July 2 PDFs were image-only scans and had to be read with OCR (optical character recognition), which is highly reliable for headings and dollar figures but can garble the occasional character in dense tables. One consequence: April's exact single-client employment exemption dollar figure did not extract cleanly from the scan, so it is described here qualitatively (a fully-exempt threshold plus a partial-exemption band) rather than quoted. Every other figure in this report was read directly from the manuals. All “better/worse” judgments are an interpretation from the recipient's point of view, not statements from the government.